

Diabetes Risk Factors



In the United States, about 115.2 million adults ages 18 or older, including 31.3 million adults age 65 or older, may have prediabetes, and many people with Type 1 and Type 2 diabetes do not know they have it. Knowing your risk can help you take steps early to protect your health.

Some diabetes risk factors can be changed through lifestyle choices. These are called modifiable risk factors. Other risk factors cannot be changed and are called non-modifiable risk factors.

Non-modifiable risk factors for Type 2 diabetes

These factors increase the chance of developing prediabetes or Type 2 diabetes but they cannot be changed:

- **Family history:** Your risk is higher if a parent or sibling has diabetes. Sharing your family health history with your healthcare professional can help guide your care.
- **Race or ethnic background:** Black people, Hispanic/Latino people, Native Americans, Asian Americans and Pacific Islanders have a higher risk of developing diabetes.
- **Age:** Risk increases as you get older. Type 2 diabetes is more common after age 45. However, more children and teens are now being diagnosed.
- **Gestational diabetes:** If you had diabetes during pregnancy, you have a higher chance of developing Type 2 diabetes later in life.

Modifiable risk factors for Type 2 diabetes

These are risk factors you can take action on. Healthy changes can lower your risk or delay diabetes.

- **Weight:** Carrying excess weight increases the risk of developing diabetes. Losing 5% to 10% of body weight, along with regular physical activity, can help lower risk. Your risk continues to decrease with additional weight loss. Even small, steady changes can help. Learn how to [manage your weight](#).
- **Physical activity:** Not being active can raise the risk for prediabetes and Type 2 diabetes. [Regular movement](#) helps the body use insulin better. For overall cardiovascular and metabolic health, aim for:
 - At least 150 minutes per week of moderate-intensity aerobic activity (such as walking, dancing or yardwork), or
 - 75 minutes per week of vigorous activity (such as running, biking or swimming),
 - Plus, muscle-strengthening activities at least two days per week.

Even a 30-minute brisk walk five days per week can make a meaningful difference.

- **Blood pressure:** Untreated high blood pressure can damage the heart and blood vessels and raise the risk of diabetes complications. A goal of below 130/80 mm Hg is often recommended for adults living with diabetes and high blood pressure. Below 120/80 mm Hg is considered normal for most adults. Your healthcare team can help set a goal that is right for you. Learn more about [high blood pressure and how to control it](#).
- **Smoking:** Smoking increases the risk of diabetes complications and heart disease. Quitting smoking is one of the most powerful steps you can take for your health. Talk with your healthcare team about [tools and programs](#) that can help you quit.

By focusing on [healthy daily habits](#), you can take control of many diabetes risk factors. Taking action now can prevent or delay development of diabetes and support your overall well-being.

Last Reviewed: Jul 8, 2026



Diabetes

About Diabetes	+
Diabetes Complications and Risks	+
Diabetes Risk Factors	
Symptoms, Diagnosis and Monitoring of Diabetes	+
Preventing and Treating Diabetes	+
Diabetes Tools and Resources	
What You Need to Know and Ways to Support Your Health	

Related Articles